

Country Background

The Democratic Republic of the Congo, commonly known as the DRC or Congo-Kinshasa, is located in Central Africa. It borders the Republic of the Congo, the Central African Republic, South Sudan, Uganda, Rwanda, Burundi, Tanzania, Zambia, and Angola.

The DRC is one of Africa's largest countries and has extensive forests, rivers, agricultural land, and mineral resources. It possesses significant deposits of cobalt, copper, gold, coltan, tin, diamonds, and other minerals.

The country has more than 200 ethnic communities and many local languages. French is the official language, while Lingala, Swahili, Kikongo, Tshiluba, and numerous other languages are widely spoken.

Despite its natural resources, the DRC continues to face poverty, weak infrastructure, limited access to healthcare and education, corruption, political instability, armed conflict, displacement, and recurring disease outbreaks.

Colonial Rule and Independence

The DRC gained independence from Belgium on 30 June 1960. The first years of independence were marked by political instability, military mutinies, regional secession movements, and foreign interference.

In 1965, Joseph-Désiré Mobutu seized power and later ruled the country as Mobutu Sese Seko. He renamed the country Zaire and governed through a highly centralized political system for more than three decades.

Mobutu's government weakened public institutions, controlled political life, and faced accusations of corruption, repression, and economic mismanagement.

First Congo War

The First Congo War began in 1996 after the 1994 genocide in Rwanda and the arrival of large numbers of refugees and armed groups in eastern Zaire.

Rwandan and Ugandan forces supported an alliance led by Laurent-Désiré Kabila. The alliance overthrew Mobutu in 1997, and the country was renamed the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

The war left eastern communities deeply militarized and increased tensions between local communities, foreign forces, armed groups, and the central government.

Second Congo War

The Second Congo War began in 1998 after relations deteriorated between President Laurent-Désiré Kabila and former regional allies.

Several African countries became involved. Rwanda and Uganda supported rebel groups, while Angola, Zimbabwe, Namibia, and other states supported the Congolese government.

The conflict spread across large parts of the country and involved numerous armed groups. It caused widespread killings, sexual violence, disease, food insecurity, economic destruction, and displacement.

Although formal peace agreements were signed in 2002 and 2003, violence continued in eastern DRC. The Second Congo War is often described as one of the deadliest conflicts since the Second World War because of the enormous number of deaths from fighting, hunger, disease, and the collapse of essential services.

Armed Groups in Eastern DRC

Eastern DRC remains affected by many armed groups. Their strength, alliances, names, and areas of control change over time.

Important armed actors have included:

- The March 23 Movement, commonly known as M23.
- The Allied Democratic Forces, commonly known as the ADF.
- The Democratic Forces for the Liberation of Rwanda, known as the FDLR.
- Mai-Mai and other community-based armed groups.
- The Cooperative for the Development of the Congo, known as CODECO.
- The National Resistance Council for Renewal and other local armed formations.

Some armed groups claim to protect their ethnic communities or defend territory. Others are involved in mining, taxation, smuggling, land disputes, recruitment, and attacks against civilians.

The existence of many armed groups makes the conflict complex. Violence is not caused by one organization alone, and responsibility for specific incidents must be determined through reliable investigations.

M23 and the Recent Escalation

M23 was formed by former members of the National Congress for the Defence of the People who integrated into the Congolese army under a 2009 peace agreement. The group mutinied in 2012 and captured Goma before being pushed out of the city.

M23 re-emerged in 2021 and expanded its operations in North Kivu. The group has captured and contested major towns and roads and has repeatedly fought Congolese government forces and allied armed groups.

In 2025, M23 captured Goma and later advanced toward Bukavu. The fighting caused mass displacement, civilian casualties, disruption of humanitarian operations, and the collapse of services in several areas.

The United Nations and other international bodies have reported allegations of external support to M23, including support attributed to Rwanda. Rwanda has denied supporting the movement. The issue remains politically sensitive and should be described using carefully sourced language.

ADF and Ituri Violence

The Allied Democratic Forces, or ADF, has carried out attacks in North Kivu and Ituri. The group has been linked to the Islamic State and has attacked villages, roads, schools, health facilities, and places of worship.

ADF attacks have included killings, abductions, forced recruitment, sexual violence, destruction of property, and displacement. Civilians in remote communities are particularly vulnerable because government security and humanitarian services are limited.

Ituri has also experienced violence involving CODECO and other armed groups. Local conflicts over land, ethnicity, political representation, customary authority, and access to natural resources have intensified the humanitarian crisis.

Natural Resources and the Conflict

Mineral resources are an important factor in the conflict, particularly in eastern DRC. Armed groups, military units, local authorities, traders, and criminal networks may compete for control of mines, transport routes, taxation systems, and border crossings.

Mineral revenues can finance weapons, recruitment, illegal taxation, and military operations. Artisanal miners may work in unsafe conditions and may be exposed to forced labour, exploitation, child labour, and violence.

The presence of valuable minerals is not the only cause of the conflict. Political exclusion, ethnic tensions, regional insecurity, weak governance, land disputes, foreign intervention, and the failure to implement peace agreements are also important causes.

Humanitarian Situation

The DRC has one of the largest humanitarian crises in the world. OCHA reported that nearly 15 million people required humanitarian assistance, while the 2026 response plan aimed to reach approximately 7.3 million people because of severe funding limitations.

The country also has one of Africa's largest internally displaced populations. Millions of people have been displaced by armed conflict, ethnic violence, military operations, land disputes, and attacks by armed groups.

Displaced people often live in overcrowded camps, temporary settlements, schools, churches, host communities, or informal sites. Many lack adequate shelter, food, clean water, sanitation, healthcare, education, documentation, and protection.

Food Insecurity

Conflict has disrupted farming, markets, trade routes, livestock ownership, mining income, and household livelihoods.

Families may lose crops, livestock, tools, land, homes, and access to markets. Displaced households often depend on humanitarian assistance and may face high food prices and limited employment.

Children under five, pregnant women, breastfeeding mothers, older people, and people with disabilities face increased risks of severe malnutrition.

Healthcare and Disease

Armed conflict has damaged or disrupted health facilities in North Kivu, South Kivu, Ituri, and other provinces.

The DRC has faced repeated outbreaks of cholera, measles, malaria, Ebola, mpox, respiratory infections, and other diseases. Insecurity can prevent vaccination teams, doctors, nurses, and community health workers from reaching affected areas.

Women may face increased risks during pregnancy and childbirth because hospitals are distant, damaged, understaffed, or inaccessible.

Gender-Based Violence

The DRC has experienced widespread conflict-related sexual violence. Women and girls face rape, sexual slavery, forced marriage, sexual exploitation, trafficking, domestic violence, and abuse at checkpoints or during displacement.

Survivors may also face stigma, rejection, threats, pregnancy, sexually transmitted infections, injury, and psychological trauma.

Access to medical care, psychosocial services, legal assistance, and safe shelters is limited in many rural and conflict-affected areas.

Children and Education

Children are exposed to recruitment, abduction, forced labour, sexual violence, forced marriage, family separation, trafficking, and psychological trauma.

Armed groups may recruit children as fighters, porters, informants, guards, or domestic workers. Some children are forced to work in mines or perform other dangerous tasks.

Schools may be destroyed, occupied, looted, or closed because of insecurity.

Displacement frequently interrupts education and separates children from teachers, classmates, and caregivers.

Humanitarian Access

Humanitarian access is affected by active fighting, road insecurity, armed checkpoints, bureaucratic restrictions, attacks on aid workers, looting, damaged bridges, communication outages, and lack of funding.

Humanitarian organizations have called for the protection of civilians, safe access to affected communities, respect for international humanitarian law, protection of medical facilities, and a political solution to the conflict.